OLDEN GOLDIES

Neeraj Chopra and P.V. Sindhu remain the country's most favourite sportspersons. In cricket, Kohli's World Cup heroics catapult him to No. 1, while Smriti Mandhana holds on to her place among women

By SUHANI SINGH

Superstar javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra scripted more history in 2023 as he became the first Indian athlete to win the world championship and defended his Asian Games title, cementing his place at the top of the INDIA TODAY MOTN ranking among non-cricket sportsmen. In the 2024 Paris Olympics, India is expecting the world No. 1 to retain his golden touch. National football team captain Sunil Chhetri retains his place, while captain Harmanpreet Singh and P.R. Sreejesh represent hockey. Bajrang Punia, the male face of the recent wrestlers' protests, also finds a spot.

However, things don't look too bright for the top three finishers among female sportspersons. Two-time Olympic medallist P.V. Sindhu and Tokyo Games medalist Mirabai Chanu are nursing injuries, raising doubts about their form in Paris. Former hockey captain Rani Rampal (No. 3) is not in the team, which under Savita Punia (No. 5) failed to qualify for the Olympics. However, former world championships silver medal-winning wrestler Anshu Malik provides a flicker of hope.

In cricket, the Men in Blue's spectacular show at home in the Cricket World Cup followed a perfect script except for that final heartbreak. But India's quest to end its long ICC trophy drought remains alive, especially if Virat Kohli carries his scintillating WC form into 2024. He scored 765



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Q. Who is India's No. 1 sportsperson among men?

1. **NEERAJ CHOPRA** (ATHLETICS) **36.2** [31.2]

2. **SUNIL CHHETRI** (FOOTBALL) **21.4** [26.2]

3. **HARMANPREET SINGH** (HOCKEY) **7.2** [8.3]

4. **BAJRANG PUNIA** (WRESTLING) **6.6** [6.9]



5. **P.R. SREEJESH** (HOCKEY) **5.5** [5.7]

All figures in %; rest, others; Feb. '24 figures in bold, Aug. '23 in [ ]